

POU11011 — Final essay

60% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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The short version

Weight	60% of the module mark
Length	1,500 words, excluding references
Questions released	[DATE TBD] — about a month before the deadline
Due	[DATE TBD] — in the College assessment session, 11–22 December 2026, 23:00
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Assignment Submission Form as page 1
Exam	There is none. This essay is the end of the module

What this is for

The blog post asked you to run one concept over one case. This asks for something harder: a sustained argument, in answer to a question somebody else set, using the module’s toolkit across more than one case.

I am not looking for recall. A competent summary of what Lukes, Weber and Tsebelis each said is worth roughly what it costs to generate, which is now nothing. What I am looking for is the thing that is still expensive: you deciding what the question is really asking, taking a position on it, and defending that position against the strongest version of the other side.

Fifteen hundred words is short. That is on purpose. Short essays punish padding and reward people who know what their argument is before they start typing.

The questions

[DECISION for Noah — final question list is yours. Six drafts below, one per portable concept, deliberately spanning the whole term so that no student can answer having attended only half of it. Recommend releasing four to six. Each is written to require at least two cases, which is what makes the concept do comparative work rather than illustrative work.]

Answer **one**.

1. **Power.** “The most important exercises of power leave no observable trace.” Is this true, and if it is, how can political science study power at all? Answer with reference to at least two cases. (*Portable concept: the three faces of power; measurement.*)
2. **The state.** Why can some states do things that others cannot? Compare two states and argue whether the difference is best explained by capacity, legitimacy, or something else. (*Portable concept: state capacity; monopoly of legitimate violence.*)
3. **Ideology and identity.** Why do some social differences become political and most never do? Answer with reference to at least two cases, and be explicit about what would count as evidence for your explanation. (*Portable concepts: thin vs thick ideology; primordialism vs constructivism vs instrumentalism.*)
4. **Regimes.** Elections are held in states nobody would call democratic. Are these elections meaningless, or do they do real political work? Answer with reference to at least two authoritarian regimes. (*Portable concepts: repression vs co-optation; the dictator’s dilemma; minimal vs substantive definitions of democracy.*)
5. **Institutions.** “Paper constraints only bind when somebody powerful wants them to.” Assess this claim using the idea of veto players and at least two cases of constitutional or judicial constraint on an executive. (*Portable concepts: veto players; constitutionalism; institutional erosion.*)
6. **Political economy and collective action.** Why do democracies persistently under-supply things that most voters say they want — housing, or climate action, or both? Answer using a collective action or concentrated-interests argument, with at least two cases. (*Portable concepts: median voter and why it fails; collective action.*)

You may not answer a question you substantially answered in your blog post. If in doubt, ask me before the deadline.

How to write it

Most first-year essays lose marks in the same four places. Here is how to not do that.

Have an argument, and put it in the first paragraph

An argument is a claim that a reasonable person could disagree with. “Power has three faces” is not an argument; it is a summary. “The third face of power is real but unfalsifiable as usually stated, and political science should therefore treat it as a hypothesis about mechanisms rather than a claim about outcomes” is an argument.

Your introduction should say, in plain words: here is the question, here is my answer, here is how I will get there. Three or four sentences. No throat-clearing about how politics has fascinated humanity since the dawn of time.

A test. Cover everything except your first paragraph. Can a stranger say what you think? If not, rewrite it.

Answer the question that was set

The single most common way to lose a class of marks is to write a good essay about an adjacent topic. Both the LSE and TCD marking schemes say this explicitly: good answers that stray from the question set are normally capped at a lower band. Reread the question after your third draft and ask whether each paragraph is doing work for *that* question.

Use the concepts as tools, not as furniture

A concept earns its place if removing it would break your argument. If a paragraph defines something and then never uses it, cut the paragraph and buy yourself 120 words of analysis.

Comparison is where the marks are. Two cases treated together — where the comparison is the point — is worth far more than two cases described in sequence.

Take the other side seriously

Somewhere in the essay, state the strongest objection to your argument and answer it. Not a strawman. This is what “critical evaluation” and “independence of judgement” mean in the Trinity band descriptors, and it is the most reliable way to move from a II.1 into a first.

Structure

Not a template, but this shape works at 1,500 words:

Section	Words	Job
Introduction	~150	Question, answer, route
The concept	~200	Define what you are using and where it comes from
Case 1	~350	Apply it, with specifics
Case 2	~350	Apply it, and compare — do not just repeat
Objection	~250	The strongest counter-argument, and your reply
Conclusion	~150	What follows, and what you are still unsure about

Do not include a table of contents, an abstract, or subheadings unless they genuinely help. This is an essay, not a report.

Prose

Short sentences. Active voice. If you cannot say what a sentence means without reading it twice, neither can I. Spellcheck it. Read it aloud once — you will find three things you cannot hear yourself saying.

Sources and referencing

- Use **academic sources**, not just the textbook. Heywood & Laing is where you start, not where you finish. The module readings, and the recommended readings, are the obvious next step; going beyond them is what a first-class essay looks like.
- **Any consistent citation style is acceptable** — Harvard, Chicago, APA, pick one and hold to it. The [TCD Library style guide](#) will help.
- **Cite paraphrases, not just quotations.** Careless note-taking is how honest students end up in plagiarism procedures.
- **An alphabetised bibliography** at the end. It does not count toward the word limit.
- **Only cite what you have read.** If a source appears in your bibliography and you could not say what its argument is, take it out.

Sloppy or inconsistent referencing costs marks under the *referencing* criterion of the rubric. Fabricated references are an academic integrity matter.

Generative AI

The full per-assessment table is in the [module outline](#). For this assessment:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate counterarguments to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept — then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references. Sources must be ones you have actually read.
Writing assistance	Permitted only for text you have already drafted yourself — tightening, grammar, clarity, structural critique of your own draft. Generating a section from a prompt and then editing it is not “writing assistance”; that is the next row. If you use it, add a one-line note in an appendix saying which tool and what for.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted. No AI-generated text in the submitted essay, quoted and cited or otherwise. In 1,500 words every sentence is supposed to be your reasoning.
Other use	Describe it on the form, or ask me before the deadline.

I will not accuse anyone on the basis of a detector score. If something in a submission does not add

up, I will ask you to come and talk about it, and you should bring your notes and drafts.

Submission

- Word or PDF, via Blackboard, which submits to Turnitin. Not through Turnitin.com.
- **The School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form must be page 1 of your file**, with the plagiarism declaration and the GenAI disclosure completed. **A submission without a completed form is not accepted:** it is returned unmarked and treated as not submitted, accruing late penalties until you resubmit it with one. The form does not count toward your word limit, and ticking a permitted box carries no penalty.
- **State your word count at the top.** 1,500 words is a hard limit; going over incurs a penalty of three per cent.
- Your name in the file name and at the top of the essay.
- Back your work up. Computer crashes, corrupted files and internet problems are not grounds for late submission. Keep your submission receipt.

Late penalties (5 marks per day to a maximum of 20), extensions (through your College Tutor only, never retrospectively) and the plagiarism policy are in the [module outline](#) and are not repeated here.

How it is marked

Against the module rubric — **argument · use of concepts · evidence · structure and writing · referencing** — mapped to the Trinity marking bands. See [the marking rubric](#). Read it before you write.